
Data Privacy

[Click to schedule a meeting with the DITI Team](#)

When working with digital tools, it's important that we place them within their broader contexts. Given the NULab's commitment to equity, the majority of our tools are open source and free to use. This allows students and professors alike to engage with the digital humanities without having to bear the burden of cost, and it also opens up tools to those who might not have access to institutional resources. However, it is essential to remember that in signing up for a free tool you are often providing access to your data. Examples of such data include names, email addresses, financial details, or research notes that can identify an individual or the work authored by them. For example, Tableau's Terms and Conditions indicate that the entirety of your data might be utilized, shared, reproduced, and altered in a public form. Read more about this on the [Tableau Software usage agreement](#). This handout will cover some important questions around **data privacy**.

What is data privacy?

At its simplest, data privacy is a person's ability to control what of their personal information is shared and with whom. This can be understood as:

- Knowledge of what information is shared with the application/program/service in question.
- Knowledge of what third parties this data is shared with or exposed to.
- Understanding the right to recall or delete data retained by the application/program/service in question.
- Understand that any type of data openly shared with a tool can be used to maintain inequalities, render overrepresentation or [exclusion](#), and reinforce biases. Read more on visibility and hypervisibility in [Silenced and seen: the black experience](#) (institutional access is needed). People who have experienced injustice from the scientific and government systems, are likely to feel the AI harms such as facial-recognition technology, aggressive surveillance, and neglect their needs of communities. Read more about how artificial intelligence can meaningfully address social inequities visit [Bringing Communities In, Achieving AI for All](#).

- Keep in mind that data privacy laws and regulations might differ depending on the laws of the country where the given tool is officially registered. For example, read more on [Data protection in the EU](#).

How is this data accessed?

Social media, websites, and other online applications collect their users' data, ostensibly in order to provide effective services. Many organizations, including government agencies and technology companies, leverage data to gain insights into users behavior, optimize products and services, and generate revenue.

But is it always clear how or why our data is being collected?

There are two main issues that users often run into when it comes to violations of their data privacy.

The first is that users are often unaware of the extent of data collection that is occurring. This means that users are allowing these platforms and applications to collect more personal information than they were aware of. Be aware of data repurposing, a process during which the user's personal information may be moved to a different department or part of a company or sold to third-party companies without the user's awareness. Read more about this in "7: Privacy and the Other Usual Suspects" in [AI Ethics by Mark Coeckelbergh](#) (institutional access is needed). Use this video tutorial on [Privacy and Data Protection in AI Systems](#) by Safeshield Training to get a clear understanding of data protection frameworks, ways to ensure data protection, and data subject rights in AI.

The second is an unawareness of how data is being shared and with whom. This is often due to the inaccessible nature of a company/program/service's data privacy information—through the use of confusing language, burying the information within terms and conditions, or making it inaccessible to users of differing abilities.

In some cases, these platforms and applications have weak safety mechanisms around their data storage and it results in hacking which then leads to data breaches, where users' personal information is leaked. A famous example of this occurred in the 2010s, when the consulting company Cambridge Analytica collected the personal information of millions of Facebook users without their knowledge (you can learn more by [reading this New York Times article](#)). A more

recent cyberattack on the Canvas platform, used by many universities worldwide, held the personal information of thousands of students and educators for ransom (read more in this [BBC Article](#)).

What is dangerous about this?

There are a myriad of ways that the collection of a user's personal data can harm the individual. Three, in particular, come up frequently and have especially significant impacts:

- The first, and the one that has received the most attention recently, occurs when platforms and applications sell users' data to outside parties, leading to users receiving unwanted advertising often without their knowledge or consent.
- The second most often occurs when there is a data breach. Such breaches may be done by hackers with criminal intentions—such as identity theft, financial theft, or even harassment.
- The third occurs through data surveillance: when a government, company, or organization uses personal data to perpetuate oppressive or authoritarian practices.
- Fourthly, personal data can be used to subconsciously direct the activities of an individual, influencing choices around what to buy, where to go, or even who to trust. User generated data, on platforms like social media, can be sold as products. As a result, the user who is not aware or compensated for their “digital labor” becomes an exploited workforce.

How can data privacy be protected?

The first and most important way to protect your personal information is for you to ensure you are aware of when and how your data is being used on a given platform or application. This often means reading through the fine print that you scroll through before clicking “accept.” Sometimes, however, the applications of your data might be couched in language that is purposefully hard to understand. If that's the case, you can always do further research around the data protection policies of that company.

Is there a resource for this further research?

Yes! There are a myriad of resources available for understanding the ways in which your data is being collected and used by a given platform or application. An easy to use and clear website is [Common Sense Privacy Program](#), which allows you to search for a specific entity, see its privacy rating, and read through an explanation for why it received this rating. In addition, you can check the tool's privacy policy for "right to access and delete" personal data, in case you decide to erase your account or data from that tool in the future. For more information on privacy issues and relevant policy considerations for Congress visit [Generative Artificial Intelligence and Data Privacy: A Primer](#).

Artificial Intelligence (AI) Considerations

If you use AI, remember that it will store any information that you put into it as data; in other words, nothing will be private. The use of AI can worsen digital surveillance: private information can be taken without explicit user consent and used for nefarious or unethical purposes, such as [artificially mimicking a person's voice](#), [promoting misinformation and disinformation](#), or perpetrating [gender-based violence](#). If you use an application or a tool, check the section on how the tool operates and what powers it. If the tool uses AI to power itself, make sure to learn about what kind of data it was trained on and whether your own data will be used as training material. While data privacy agreements can be difficult to understand, using specific key words to locate meaningful information will make this process easier. Pay attention to the terms and phrases in privacy and user agreements that outline how your data will be collected, stored, and utilized by the tool. Consider searching for terms like "scraping," "prediction," "forecasting," "retention," and "surveillance" to quickly and efficiently navigate to the needed information. Read more about this in [Artificial Intelligency and Privacy](#) (institutional subscription needed).

If you use AI for a project that involves other peoples' personal data or information without their knowledge or consent, it would be a form of data privacy violation. To learn more about privacy and AI, see: the [University of Pittsburgh's webpage for AI and data privacy](#); MIT's [recommendations for navigating data privacy](#) with AI use; [this guide for teaching privacy and ethical guardrails](#) when using AI developed by the Department of Education; and this [research from Stanford University](#) on the potential privacy violations of AI and current policy solutions to address them. Additionally, for more on how AI uses data, also see our [Data Ethics Handout](#). For more information on Northeastern University AI policies as well as AI tutorials and tips, visit the [Northeastern Center for Advancing Teaching and Learning Through Research](#).

Digital Integration Teaching Initiative

It is important to note that due to the rapidly increasing number and complexity of AI models the full impact of the AI privacy risks are not yet fully understood. However, researchers suggest that we could use AI to mitigate some of the harms posed by the models. For more information on the organization and classification how AI handles privacy matters in existing literature visit [Both ends of artificial intelligence impacting privacy: a review of violation and protection](#).

The influence of AI and the range of its capabilities is rapidly changing, so please be aware that any considerations listed here should be taken in tandem with your current knowledge of these subjects. Please also note that you should follow your professor's stated guidelines for AI use in your class.